

Canis lupus

Gray wolf



Location North America, Greenland, Europe, Asia

Length 3–4¼ ft (0.9–1.3 m)
Tail 14–20½ ft (35–52 cm)
Weight Up to 135 lb (62 kg)
Social unit Group
Status Least concern



The gray wolf is the largest wild member of the canid family and the ancestor of the domestic dog. Once the world's most widely ranging carnivore, its distribution has since been restricted by widespread human persecution and habitat destruction. An intelligent and social animal, its survival and great

success as a predator is dependent on its organization into packs—family groups that commonly consist of 5 to 12 wolves, although this size can go up to 36 individuals. Packs patrol territories, covering very wide areas, which they maintain by scent markings. The clearly defined hierarchy within a pack centers around a dominant breeding pair that usually mates for life. By hunting in packs the gray wolf is able to take a wide range of prey, including moose and caribou, that may be up to 10 times a wolf's weight.

FEEDING PACK
Having captured their prey, the pack members wait behind the dominant pair for access to the kill.

